This view was also preached by Sufism, which appeared as a reaction against worldliness of the early Islam. Sufis believed that realisation of God can be achieved only through passionate devotion to God and intense meditation. Sufis were of the view that this type of meditation would enable the devotee to understand the true nature of God. They argued that doing so would liberate the devotee from all worldly bonds and help them become one with God. Several mystical religious movements, in both Hinduism and Islam, had no hesitation to freely include elements of different faiths in their teachings. 'There is only one god, though Hindus and Muslims call him by different names', stated Haridasa.

1. Devotional Movement in Tamizhakam (Azhwars and Nayanmars)

The Azhwars, the Vaishnavite Bhakti sages and the originators of Bhakti cult, and the Nayanmars, the worshipers of Siva or the Saivites, composed devotional hymns in Tamil language, dedicated to their respective gods. Siva-bhakti is associated with Siva's manifestations on earth. Poems to Siva and Vishnu, particularly to Krishna, were composed in Tamil and other South Indian languages such as Kannada and Telugu. These poet-saints criticised caste-based social status and advocated gender equality in order to make it good to stand the onslaught of Buddhism or Jainism.

Vishnu-*bhakti* or Vaishnavism is based on Vishnu's avatars (incarnations), particularly Krishna and Rama. The 12 Tamil Azhwars are chiefly known for their immortal hymns. Two Azhwars stand out distinctly for their contribution to the promotion of the Bhakti movement. Nammazhwar's fame lies in his 1,102-stanza *Tiruvaimozhi*. Nathamuni collected the 4,000 poems of Nammazhwar, in the form of *Divya Prabandham*. Andal, the only female Azhwar, is another. Periyazhwar, who was earlier known as Vishnu Chittar, made lots of songs on Krishna putting himself in the place of mother Yashoda. Periyazhvar is said to have found Andal as a baby in the tulsi garden at Srivilliputhur temple and adopted her. She grew up in the temple town of Srivilliputhur and became known as Andal-she who ruled. *The Thiruppavai* (The Path to Krishna) and the *Nachiyar Thirumozhi* (The Sacred Songs of the Lady) are her celebrated works. Her poems expressing her love for Ranganatha, the incarnation of Vishnu worshiped at a temple at Srirangam, are used in Vaishnava wedding ceremonies in Tamil Nadu.

Vaishnavite Saints (12 Azhwars)



Three Muthal Azhwars: Poigai Azhwar, Bhoothathu Azhwar and Pei Azhwar.
Other Azhwars: Thirumalisai Azhwar, Periyazhwar, Thondaradippodi Azhwar, Thirumangai Azhwar, Thiruppanazhwar, Kulasekara Azhwar, Nammazhwar, Mathurakavi Azhwar and Andal.

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